updates on market prices and weather conditions, ensuring that decisions are driven by data rather than guesswork. The impact of these interventions is clearly reflected in agricultural growth. While the agricultural growth rate stood at 8.6 per cent in 2016-17, it rose to 17.7 per cent in 2024-25. Uttar Pradesh now ranks first in fruit and vegetable production, generating more then 423 lakh tonnes annually. This shift signifies not just higher output, but a fundamental transformation in the nature of farming itself.

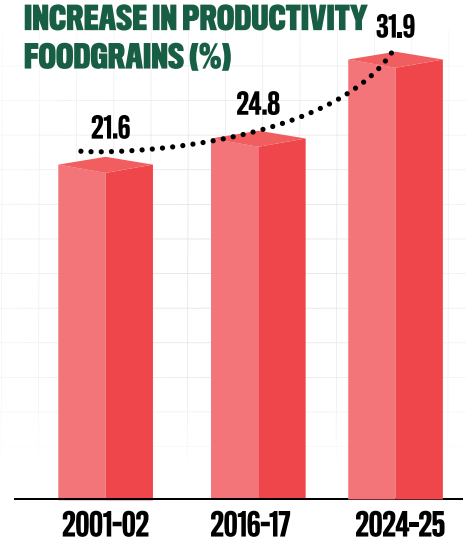
HIGHER MSP, STRONGER STABILITY

Periodic revision of the Minimum Support Price (MSP) has been a key instrument in ensuring income stability for farmers. This year, the MSP for common paddy has been fixed at ₹2,369 per quintal and Grade A paddy at ₹2,389 per quintal, marking an increase of ₹69 over the previous year. For sugarcane farmers, the price for early-maturing varieties has been raised to ₹400 per quintal, while the general variety has been set at ₹390 per quintal.

Record sugarcane payments, the establishment of new sugar mills and Uttar Pradesh's position as the national leader in ethanol production further reinforce this income-driven policy framework. Procurement reforms have played a pivotal role in linking farms to markets. Over 4,000 active procurement centres have been established across the state, with 35-40 per cent located in blocks that had lacked permanent procurement facilities for decades. Proximity-based procurement reduced transportation costs, ensured faster sales and minimised price risks bringing particular relief to small and marginal farmers.

NEW SOURCES OF INCOME

The government's approach has extended beyond production to the creation of diversified income streams. The UP-AGREES Project aims not only to enhance productivity but also to generate agriculture-based employment in rural areas. Launched with support from the World Bank, the initiative is expected to benefit nearly 10 lakh small and marginal farmers. World Bank President Ajay Banga has lauded Uttar Pradesh's agricultural model, describing it as a benchmark with global relevance.



Financial inclusion and mechanisation form another cornerstone of the income-enhancement strategy. Under the Mukhyamantri Krishak Samriddhi Yojana, farmers are provided loans at concessional interest rates. The scope of the Kisan Credit Card has been expanded, with a target to onboard 25 lakh new farmers this year. In parallel, tractors, harvesters, drones and crop residue management equipment are being made available at 50 per cent subsidy.

To ensure transparency, beneficiary selection in all 75 districts is conducted through e-lottery systems chaired by the District Magistrate. Technology-led farming practices including drone spraying, automated irrigation and digital surveys are being implemented on the ground. Village-level advisory systems, involving agricultural scientists and experts, are providing farmers with quick solutions related to crop diseases, water management and fertiliser use. Faster settlement of crop insurance claims and online platforms such as e-NAM have further simplified access to markets.

A MODEL OF WOMEN-LED EMPOWERMENT

Women's empowerment forms a vital component of this agricultural transformation. Through self-help groups, seedling production initiatives have generated employment for nearly 60,000 women. In Lucknow, a ₹251 crore Seed Park, being developed in the name of Bharat Ratna Chaudhary Charan Singh, is set to give new momentum to quality seed production and agricultural research.

Parallel investments in irrigation and infrastructure have strengthened agriculture as an industry. The Har Khet Tak Pani mission, the Ken-Betwa link in Bundelkhand, and the expansion of rural roads, cold-chain facilities and storage networks have collectively enhanced farm resilience. By promoting Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs), agri-drone operators and organic farming, the state is steadily transforming farmers from producers into entrepreneurs.

DIGITAL AGRICULTURE ECOSYSTEM

The Yogi government is making agriculture-related data available to farmers through an integrated digital platform. Farmers can now easily access information related to seeds, fertilisers, weather, irrigation, insurance, markets, logistics and crops. The digital agriculture policy has been aligned with international technologies. In Uttar Pradesh, digitisation, e-market linkages, warehousing, processing and export-oriented policies are infusing new vitality into the rural economy.